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Words and the Dogon world

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For its part, the symbolic gesture of throwing handfuls of dust at a dancer has a dual meaning in addition to its predominant congratulatory function. The first compares the masks to wind, for they share lightness and strength. Yet this allusion to wind is at the same time an allusion to death, itself "wind and dust." It means that the "dance will not go beyond the public square and will not spill over into the home," for a person who tires himself from dancing will not be able to restore himself for work the next morning. "The dance will fall like the dust it raises, carried away by the wind."¹²⁶ The dancers need this encouragement, and they show less zeal and agility when it is lacking. In cases where a dancer is taunted and criticized, he leaves the square to hide in shame.

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Disputes are resolved by bearers of verbal authority who serve as judges and peacemakers. We observed the importance of the mediator's role in connection with the mending of bad speech. When a blacksmith or "joking relative" does not fill this position, the "speech of justice" (báru s`[unavailable]:) comes into play. It issues from three supreme authorities: the Hogon, the family head, and the council of elders, with the present-day addition of the administrative authority.

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The justice of the Hogon, who is the “spokesman” for the ancestor Lebe Seru, intervenes only in the most serious cases. The typical example is a case of late rains, where a man is thought to have delayed their fall either willfully or because he has broken a taboo. Then the Hogon calls all the inhabitants of the region together, and the person who fails to respond to the call is considered the guilty one. He is forced to come before the Hogon, and it is believed ⁴⁵⁷ that the rains will follow. The justice of the marketplace (ib[unknown] báru) formerly issued ¹²⁷ from the exclusive authority of the Hogon, and in a case of disagreement or theft, his messenger would arrive playing the “Hogon's drum” ([unavailable]g[unavailable] bòy) and pass judgment there in his name.

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126. We also think that this gesture has a propitiatory value meant to keep death from the houses and contain its influence on the public square, especially while the ceremony is in progress.

127. Today offenses of this type are the accepted province of administrative justice. According to our informants, thefts occur much more frequently now than before, whereas open conflicts have become rarer as imprisonment is the penalty for seriously wounding an adversary.

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